

Shachi Shah

Architectural Designer | Environmental Psychologist | Behavioural Researcher

India (open to relocation) | +91 9930514470 | shachi.o.shah@gmail.com | [LinkedIn](#) | [Portfolio](#)

PROFILE

Architectural designer and environmental psychologist with six years of practice and postgraduate training in how built environments shape human behaviour, wellbeing, and social identity. Holds an MSc in Environmental Psychology from the University of Surrey covering behaviour change, qualitative methodology, and the psychological mechanisms through which physical surroundings influence what people do and feel. Fieldwork spans independently conducted qualitative studies, participatory community research across multiple countries and the direct application of these frameworks to spatial and landscape intervention. Currently running an independent practice at the intersection of spatial inquiry, behavioural observation and the textures of everyday life.

WORK EXPERIENCE

Architect-Designer and Head of Business Development | **Incredible Garden Art** *January 2026 – Present*
Vadodara, India | *Garden design and public space practice*

- Directs the EME Temple Garden project, a neglected civic space in Vadodara revitalised through government and corporate CSR partnership. The intervention is structured around pro-environmental behaviour theory: sustained ecological responsibility follows from genuine sensory and emotional immersion in natural settings, not from aesthetic appeal alone.
- Oversees all projects across hardscape and softscape, including a 60,000 sq ft corporate garden for Yash High Voltage, event landscaping for Anita Dongre's Rewild 2026, and a jungle-themed installation at Vantara, using spatial and sensory logic to shape how audiences inhabit each environment.
- Runs a CSR vertical from urban space identification through government approval, evidence-led proposal development and corporate pitch, moving fluidly between the register of community need, design rationale and commercial decision-making.
- Manages brand positioning, client relationships, new business outreach and the overall communication direction of the practice.

Founder | **Note: Nuances of the Everyday** *2024 – Present*
Independent Research and Creative Practice

- An independent studio examining the psychological, sensory and cultural dimensions of ordinary environments, working across spatial inquiry, object making and design education.
- Developing a structured module for architecture programmes embedding tools absent from most curricula: sensory audits, post-occupancy evaluation and in-situ behaviour mapping as methods for critically assessing built outcomes.
- Actively documenting human-environment observations, alongside ongoing exploration of wellbeing-oriented object and material work.

Architectural Designer | **Studio 3 Designs** *October 2020 – July 2022*
Vadodara, India

- Led schematic design for the North Stand of the Kotambi International Cricket Stadium, a five-level broadcast and media facility within a 30,000-capacity civic venue. Decisions around circulation, sightlines, and assembly flow were made in direct relation to how crowds navigate and occupy large public structures.
- Produced master plans, movement networks and wayfinding systems for public, commercial and housing typologies totalling over 150,000 sq ft, applying legibility and navigational logic to each at a macro and micro scale.
- Coordinated construction documentation and contractor communication for apartment buildings and fitted interiors, including 3D output for client presentation and lease conversion.

Intern Architect | **Kakani Associates** *November 2018 – April 2019*
Ahmedabad, India

- Conceived outdoor learning and restoration zones for The Gaudium School, independently drawing on attention restoration theory and nature connectedness to reframe a holistic education brief into a spatial strategy. The resulting environments were structured to support cognitive recovery, unstructured play, and emotional regulation alongside formal instruction.
 - Catalogued traditional construction methods including Rohtak Domes, Timbrel Vaults and Filler Slabs in written and photographic form, building a reference base for ecologically considered future projects.
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EDUCATION

MSc Environmental Psychology *Merit* | 2022 – 2023

University of Surrey, Guildford, UK | Vice-Chancellor's Excellence Scholarship (45% tuition waiver)

- Modules: Psychology of Real-World Behaviour Change, Social Change and Influence, Psychology of Architecture and Planning, Qualitative and Quantitative Research Methods, Key Questions in Environmental Psychology.
- Dissertation: *Interplay between Place Identity and Affordances, An Inquiry into London's Brick Lane*. A fully independent qualitative study: semi-structured interviews (n=11), manual transcription, Braun and Clarke thematic analysis. Themes identified: everchanging landscape, echoes of the past, community spirit and transformation of the neighbourhood.
- Academic Research Training: Architectural Experience and Cognition, The Experience of Wayfinding.

Bachelor of Architecture (B.Arch) *CGPA 8.34* | 2015 – 2020

School of Environment and Architecture, Mumbai, India

- Design Thesis: *Interpretative Capacities of Built-Form*. An investigation into how the physical qualities of public spaces generate conditions for varied occupation, meaning-making and social use.

RESEARCH AND FIELDWORK

- Student Exchange, Tongji University, Shanghai (2017): Observational and participatory inquiry into courtyard housing communities, conducted under a complete language barrier. A gamified wooden block model was devised as a non-verbal instrument, enabling residents to communicate spatial preferences and daily patterns through physical arrangement rather than interview. Outcomes fed into a co-produced intervention proposal.
- Kochi-Muziris Biennale (2016): Contributed to *The Itinerant Home*, an installation probing transient belonging and attachment through found materials and spatial arrangement. Part of a cross-disciplinary team working at the intersection of cultural research and public engagement.
- Ongoing: Introduction to Psychology, Yale University; Designing a Wayfinding System, Planetizen Courses (1 AICP CM Credit).

ADDITIONAL EXPERIENCE

Deputy Manager | M&S Food | SSP Group 2023 – 2025

Guildford, UK | High-footfall commuter retail

- Applied choice architecture and visual merchandising to product placement decisions outside the parent company planogram, testing how categorical and physical context shapes purchasing behaviour. Reframing a product's position within the store to shift its perceived affordance from impulse to intentional choice produced consistently faster sell-through than the same item placed elsewhere, demonstrating how context alone alters decision-making without changing the product itself.
- Observed and interpreted how a full store renovation altered customer behaviour at a systemic level, tracking changes in flow, dwell time and purchasing patterns as friction at checkout was reduced and new spatial opportunities were introduced. Translated these observations into an understanding of how environmental configuration shapes decision-making in high footfall, time pressured contexts.

Volunteer Teacher | Khar Educational Society 2018 – 2019

Mumbai, India

- Ran values-based sessions for children aged 4 to 7, cultivating critical thinking and group collaboration within a diverse volunteer teaching team.

SKILLS AND LANGUAGES

Research methods: Semi-structured interviews, thematic analysis (Braun and Clarke), observational fieldwork, participatory design, sensory audits, post-occupancy evaluation, behaviour mapping

Theoretical frameworks: Choice architecture, nudge theory, affordance theory, place identity and attachment, attention restoration theory, pro-environmental behaviour, social influence

Design software: Adobe Suite (Photoshop, Illustrator, InDesign, Premiere Pro, After Effects), Affinity Suite, AutoCAD, Revit, SketchUp, Vectorworks, Rhinoceros

Other: Hand drafting, model making, digital illustration, basic carpentry | Currently learning: Figma

Data tools: Jamovi, Qualtrics, Microsoft Excel

Languages: English (advanced), Hindi (advanced), Gujarati (native), Marathi (conversational)

References available on request.